Chapter 1: Some People Aren't Supposed to Exist

Kinston took a deep breath and walked up to the party of Mage Templars, known as the Demon's Bane, near a blue portal. The party of mages looked strong and the blue portal intimidating. The thunderstorm that was nearing didn't help. The sky was dark gray with thunder booming through the sky and lightning flashing in the distance. The storm would be there very soon.

He was met by a muscular man who led the group. "What do you want?"

"I am to observe here today," Kinston answered, extending his hand. "I am to be made a templar soon."

The leader chuckled, not taking his hand, but pointing back the direction Kinston came. "Son, you need to go observe a safer portal. Those considering becoming templars are only allowed around gray and purple portals. The blue and gold portals are too dangerous. What are you, seventeen?"

"Eighteen," Kinston corrected as he pulled a parchment from his belt and held it out.

The man took it from him. As he read, his eyes went wide in disbelief. It was signed by King Helios himself.

“Kinston Foster,” the leader mumbled with a nod. “I have heard of you.”

“Many people have,” Kinston replied. “Mostly due to Willow.”

The man playfully punched Kinston’s arm and chuckled. “It’s not every man who gets to court a princess. You are lucky.” He handed the parchment to another party member and announced, “Everyone, this is Kinston. He is going to observe today. Let’s hope the portal doesn’t get too dangerous.”

“I hope not,” Kinston seconded.

The leader placed a welcoming hand on Kinston’s shoulder. “Is this your first observation?”

“Yes,” Kinston answered. “I was allowed to fight with the templars in the gray and purple gates I was assigned to observe, so this is my first real observation.”

“Impressive,” the leader noted. He held his hand out. “I am Preston. I’ve been a templar for seven years and lead this group. Let’s hope all goes smoothly today.”

Kinston shook his hand, his eyes filled with awe. “Seven years. I bet you’ve seen a great deal of excitement.”

“Indeed,” Preston confirmed. “I have dealt with many blue and gold portals, and seen horrors that could keep you from becoming a templar.”

Kinston stiffened. “Do you think I shouldn’t? I don’t really have a choice.”

Preston looked over him. Kinston was almost six feet tall. He had fairly tanned skin, golden brown hair, and glowing blue eyes. Obviously, he was a sun mage. Preston knew sun mages well, as he was one, his light

golden hair and glowing blue eyes instantly identifying him.

Preston finished summing Kinston up from his appearance. “What’s your magic?”

“I can control metal,” Kinston answered. “I’m very good with swords and daggers.”

Preston again inspected him. He had muscle, definitely he was strong enough to wield a sword. “I’m guessing you’ve been trained extensively.”

Kinston rolled his eyes. “For a long time. Think about it. I make King Helios look bad if I’m not a great templar. I have to impress people.”

Preston put his hand on Kinston’s shoulder. “That would be a lot of pressure. I don’t even know getting a princess would be worth it.”

Kinston stiffened, a forced smile crossing his face. “That wasn’t my decision. King Helios and my father have arranged our courtship.”

Preston laughed. “No pressure, right?”

Kinston’s lips tightened. “Right.”

Preston then took Kinston over to his party. There was a wooden lodge very near, where the parties stayed when they were assigned to the portal. Generally lodges to house the templars were built by each portal when it appeared. The party was sitting on benches outside of it, near the portal. One member was standing directly in front of the portal, looking into it. Preston explained there were currently three parties assigned there, but they rotated, so they were taking guard, and if too many demons came out, they would sound a horn for the others to come.

Three parties total… Kinston thought for a moment. Each party generally had three sun mages for fire power, two moon mages for stealth, tracking, and pursuit if a demon broke away, and a star mage. Star mages weren't usually helpful in a fight, but they took care of all the other needs… cooking, cleaning, mending clothing, carrying supplies… Every party needed one. With three parties, that meant that at most there could be nine sun mages fighting. What if there was a stampede? What if dozens of demons came out?

Sure, a sun mage could handle several husks, as they were soulless demons who fought in a mindless state, feeding on destruction. They were the weakest demons, the first ones ever known, originating with the original gray portals. Still they were tough.

He'd fought them, and a few sirens too. Sirens are the demons from the purple portals. They can fly and have a hypnotic effect, which makes them hard to fight against. When Kinston went to the purple gate to aid in a fight, the party all had ear plugs of some sort to keep the sirens from entirely immobilizing them. Even then, the siren song penetrated them, slowing them significantly. Sirens and husks were the only two types of demons Kinston had seen.

Blue portals were known for icell hounds, black hounds with sharp teeth that breathe ice. "Are hounds as hard to fight as I hear?" Kinston suddenly blurted out.

"They aren't fun," Preston answered. "I'd rather fight them though than gremgols."

Kinston clasped his hands together. "You've fought gremgols? I've heard of them. Aren't they mischievous little creatures who can summon golden warriors?"

“Yes,” Preston confirmed. “Those demons are tough. The warriors are tough enough. They look like animated armor made of gold, sort of extreme versions of husks, but the pesky gremgols always have some trick up their sleeve. When you fight them, expect to be magically slightly confused, suddenly burst out laughing, or start to see colored lights all around. It’s what I think star mages might be like if they were evil – tons of sneaky parlor tricks that can really annoy and get in the way of the fight.”

Kinston sighed. “I guess I’ll see what they are like at some point.”

“Not today,” Preston assured him. “I’ve never seen a gremgol come from a blue portal. They only come from gold portals.”

Kinston looked over at the portal. It was a large archway that had grown from the ground. Bones of the dead were trapped in the stone archway, and the inside swirled with an opaque blue mist. It was bigger than the gray and purple portals he’d seen. They had been about twelve feet tall and fifteen wide. The blue portal was fifteen feet tall and about twenty wide.

“It is intimidating when you first see it,” a lady in the party told him, seeing he was eyeing the portal. By the streak of glowing hair, he could tell she was the star mage of the group. “Don’t worry though. We’ll protect you. You can back up and watch.”

“It’s best if you do,” Preston urged. “You could get in the way.”

A girl with dark hair, dark eyes, and glowing fingernails, who had a bow in her hand, called over, “Don’t worry. There were four demons who came

through the portal this morning. I wouldn't expect more for a day or two. Blue gates aren't as active as gray and purple."

"But they are tougher," the star mage noted.

"Don't worry about a thing," Preston assured Kinston. "Have you heard of Demon's Bane? We are a strong party." He pointed to another sun mage. "That's Flint. He does fire. I do cutting light beams." He then pointed to a man, who was obviously a moon mage, standing looking into the portal and a large sun mage near him. "They are both really good at taking hits, real tanks." He next pointed to the dark-haired girl. "She's great with a bow. We've won some tough fights."

Kinston found out how tough they were all too soon. Only minutes later, the portal began to swirl faster and dark blue lightning began to spark from within.

"Husks!" the moon mage watching the portal called as the other moon mage readied her bow, and the strong sun mage in heavy plate armor stepped up to the portal and raised his shield.

Suits of living armor forged from dark bones shambled out of the portal, each movement an instant twitch as if being dragged by invisible strings. Without any visible warning, one of them twisted his body, swinging his arm directly for the head of its first foe. The strong sun mage raised his shield to block the blow as he raised his war-hammer and slammed it into the husk. The husk screamed an unearthly howl as its arm was separated from its body and its head slammed into the warrior in an unnatural thrust, repeating until its helmet cracked. Another husk swung from the side of the templar's shield, the tank blocking the sword with his

free hand. A third husk flung itself to the side, stabbing the upper arm of the tank.

Preston blasted a stream of deadly knife-edged light rays directly into the husk's neck, its head falling to the ground as the burning white eyes in the helmet faded.

"Thanks," the tank gasped as the sword slid out of his arm, leaving the open wound bleeding.

Preston turned to the other tank as he replied, "Thank me later, Flint!"

Flint responded by calling, "Shield!" so the tanks would protect him as he shot simple sparks toward the demons that suddenly exploded into a flaming whirlwind.

The tanks blocked the fire with their shields as the uninjured one raised his hand towards his comrades bloody arm. A small cone of light emanated from his hand and the wound began to close, with no noticeable change on the other man's face from the alleviation of the pain he had commanded himself not to feel. As soon as the fire died down, the tanks moved their shields aside and smashed the remaining husks.

The portal sparked again, growls emanating from the portal before the bow wielding moon mage called a warning again. "Hounds!" Everyone immediately went on edge, as the injured tank stepped forward, arms spread as the other tank shrunk back slightly. Just as quickly as they reacted, eight spiked hounds with black and white fur bounded out, the air began to freeze around them. They latched onto the closer tank with their sharp and frigid fangs ripping into the man's muscles. He forced himself forward, getting three more hounds that just charged out of the portal attacking him, single-handedly holding half of them back.

Flint made the hounds burst into flames as the moon mage started firing arrows at them as fast as she could. Seven more ran to the other tank, their claws digging into the steel of the shield as their ice cold breath started freezing him. He fell back a bit as he started shaking from the cold. Still determined to help his teammate, he held his arm out to heal the other tank. As he did, a hound snapped over and bit into his hand, making him scream in agony. He threw the hound to the ground, using his foot to pry it's jaw off. With a firm stomp, the jaw snapped off as it let out a gruesome howl. He quickly pulled his hand back as he healed himself. The hounds still trying to over-power him as the hound missing its jaw started clawing at his leg.

The star mage ran behind the tank and used her magic to repair the steel, with the claws still embedded. The moon mage noticed his cries of pain and started trying to help him with his shots.

Two other hounds ran past the tanks, a trail of frozen, dead land following them as they ran towards Flint. Flint quickly set their faces on fire, temporarily blinding them and causing them to split off.

The star mage blew her horn, alerting the templars in the barracks. One of the hounds noticed Kinston and ran at him. He quickly pulled out his swords before throwing them. One sword lodging itself into the hound's heart as the other flew in from the side, not only stabbing through the eye sockets but tearing through the head and flying out the other side, the momentum throwing the hound to the ground with it clawing the ground around it, trying to get up.

Kinston definitely was no longer observing. Demon's Bane were excellent fighters, better than the templars

he'd worked with at the gray and purple portals he'd "observed." Yet, the scene around him was terrifying. The icell hounds attacked as a pack, ripping through flesh easily and ready to tear any party member to pieces if he made even the slightest error as he fought.

As Kinston fought, he heard Preston call out, "Are you all right?" to Flint, who called back, "I'd better be," as he lit his wounds on fire to cauterize them.

Kinston didn't have time to worry about Flint, as icell hounds charged at him. He thrust the four daggers from his belt toward them. If only he'd brought more, but he wasn't coming to fight. With a sword in each hand and four knives being controlled with his mind, he took on the hounds.

"Behind you!" the star mage called to Preston, who turned to see a hound pouncing. There was no time to react. Fortunately, one of Kinston's swords whizzed by, slicing the throat of the hound cleanly. It still didn't die, but Preston used his knife edged light to cut the head the rest of the way off.

Kinston felt good about victory until the moon mage with the bow called out, "Sirens!" as she nocked an arrow and pointed it at the portal, which sparked. A low dreary humming sound with vibrating echoes emanated from the portal.

Kinston instantly went alert. He'd fought sirens when he "observed" the purple portal. They were called sirens because of their song, if the sound they made could be considered music. They were not beautiful ladies who enchanted with song, but demon hags with wings whose shrieking song made all paralyze in fear, not charm.

As soon as the siren breached the portal, Preston

blasted with fire and the moon mage shot multiple arrows, killing most of the sirens, as their flesh was extremely sensitive to fire. Yet, there were just too many, so five remained in the air. Their eerie hum turned to a shrieking whale.

Kinston froze in fear. Apparently, Demon's Bane counted on their fire to kill sirens and didn't use earplugs, as they limited communication. That meant all of them were affected by the hideous sound. Kinston stood, paralyzed, watching as everyone in Demon's Bane froze. He felt as if time stood still as he took the scene in. The two tanks had hounds about to rip them apart. One was frozen in ice half way up his body, and the other coated in a thin layer of ice. Five more husks and two hounds were coming through the portal. They were all about to die. Unfortunately, time wasn't holding still, so Kinston had to act, and fast.

He knew he could stop the effect of the sirens on him. How? He had no clue, but the mere thought to push the sound away from him worked, which he had to keep secret. He glanced up at the stormy sky, which would soon release a tremendous storm. That didn't help the fight. He tense, knowing what he had to do and the terrible trouble he'd get in for doing it, as he was supposed to keep his ability secret, but lives were at stake.

He raised his hands up, focusing on the sky, directing the lightning down, zapping all the sirens in the air, and sending arcs of lightning down to strike the hounds.

As soon as the siren's sound stopped, Preston, Flint, and the moon bowman started fighting again.

Both tanks were still frozen in ice. Kinston hurried

over to them. He placed one hand on the ice block and the other on the thin layer of ice around the other, heating the ice to melt it. Very quickly, both men broke free and ran in to fight the husks and hounds coming through the portal.

As they did, the other two parties arrived. The fight after that was quick, as the well-trained templars had more numbers and skillfully beat the demons. Kinston stepped back, hoping the parties would report that he only observed.

When the battle was over, the moon tank collapsed on the ground and the other went to healing him.

“What’s going on?” Kinston asked. “Did he take a hit I didn’t see?”

“No,” the star mage answered. “His moon magic gives him the ability to fight through any pain or wound, but when he is done fighting, the wounds take their toll, and he feels the agonizing pain. Fortunately, our sun mage tank has the magic of healing, which is why he can take so much damage. He heals himself very quickly, and can heal others too.”

That was a relief. Kinston wasn’t eager to see someone die.

He took a deep breath to calm himself and listened to all the talk about the fight.

“Did you see how well I was shooting?” the moon mage archer asked.

“I had a shield jump in front of me and save my life,” a tank noted. “That was some amazing fight.”

The were many stories told, and wounds were tended to. During it, Preston walked over to Kinston. “Thank

you for your help. You are quite talented at controlling metal." He glanced around cautiously before whispering, "Do you want me to leave out that you helped during the fight in my report, or should I say you helped from the rear?"

Kinston shrugged. "Either way. Just please don't say I fought and killed demons. Fortunately, the templars outside your team didn't see me do that."

Preston then put his hand on Kinston's shoulder, met his eyes, and asked, "How did you do it?"

"What?" Kinston asked, feigning innocence.

"You know," Preston insisted. "How did you call the lightning?"

"I didn't," Kinston lied.

Preston's eyes stared into his, a piercing stare that seemed to look deep inside him. "I saw you do it. We were hypnotized, but our eyes still worked, and that was no illusion. How did you break out of the hypnotism? How did you control lighting? You then melted the ice using heat. No sun mage can use more than one power, and you used at least three?"

Every muscle in Kinston's body went to instant alert. What should he say? After a moment of hesitation, he blurted out, "I'm sorry." He then pleaded, "Can we keep my powers a secret between me and your team?"

Preston raised his eyebrows. "Perhaps if you tell me how you do it."

"I can't tell you that," Kinston refused. He looked away, then turned back with confidence, placed his hand authoritatively on Preston's shoulder, and declared, "That is a secret I must keep by king's command. Please, do not

tell anyone I did the lightning or heat. In fact, deny it. King Helios will be angry if anyone tells."

Preston nodded agreement. He then went back to the group. Everyone was still talking of the battle, and when someone mentioned the lighting, Preston called it a stroke of luck, perhaps God intervening for them.

The sun mage archer eyed Kinston knowingly, so he looked away. Would they keep his secret? They all had to know.

One of the templar parties took watch of the gate, and Preston's group was supposed to go to the lodge to recover, but he insisted, "We need to report this immediately. A surge of dozens is not normal for a portal, particularly this one. Let's go."

Kinston immediately headed off with Demon's Bane. It wouldn't take long to get to headquarters by horse, as the portal was in the woods in the outskirts of the city.

As they neared the castle, they saw people busily setting up for the big event the next day.

Preston motioned to it. "I assume you are part of that, Kinton."

"Yes," Kinston confirmed, his voice lacking enthusiasm for such a high honor. "I should be. At least if the king isn't too angry with me."

The party continued to headquarters. Captain Webb oversaw the templars, so they reported to him. He listened, very concerned about the surge of demons, pacing in thought. Suddenly, the large oak door flew opened and King Helios stepped in the room, his mere appearance demanding instant respect.

Everyone stood up and humbly bowed to the king,

looking down at the stone floor beneath their feet.

"Arise," Helios ordered. "Sit." He strode to the front of the group. "I have heard that there was a surge, but despite the numbers, the templars came out with no deaths and complete victory. That is impressive." A proud smile graced his face, but he glared at Kinston, meeting his eyes with sharp daggers.

The tank of the party explained, "We couldn't have done it if lightning hadn't happened to strike. We lucked out."

Again, Helios's eyes went to Kinston with piercing accusation. Kinston shied back from him and looked away. The king then finished listening to the report and swore everyone to secrecy about the lightning and where it came from if they knew.

When he finished with the others, he commanded Kinston, "You will meet with me now."

Helios led Kinston to a parlor where they could both speak knowing no ears could hear. Kinston took a seat, but Helios stood above him, glared down at him, and scolded, "You are supposed to keep your power except for metal hidden!"

Kinston pushed back against his chair, wishing he could move father away, and meekly defended, "I'm sorry. I couldn't let people die."

"Templars die all the time," Helios fumed. "No, I don't want them dead either, but I am more afraid of what will happen if people find out that people like you exist!"